

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 918

By Stinnett

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Thomas William Taylor on the celebration of his eightieth birthday.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we pay tribute to those citizens who are celebrating special occasions in their estimable lives; and

WHEREAS, Thomas William Taylor celebrates his eightieth birthday this year, a milestone that will be commemorated as yet another precious souvenir of life's rich pageant; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Taylor was born on February 21, 1946, in Maryville to the late Frances Kinton Taylor and J. Wilson Taylor; he graduated from Maryville High School in 1964, earned a Bachelor of Science degree in Biology from Maryville College in 1970, and received an honorary Doctor of Public Service from Maryville College in 2021; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Taylor subsequently completed graduate work at the University of Tennessee Medical Units in Memphis and the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, Department of Ecology, where he was a graduate teaching assistant and research assistant; and

WHEREAS, from 1971 to 1976, Tom Taylor taught in the Maryville College Department of Biology while also serving as Camp Director of the U.S. Department of the Interior Youth Conservation Corps (YCC) in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park during the summers; under his guidance, the program was the first YCC program to offer enrollment for the deaf and hearing impaired and also to attain Equal Employment Opportunity goals for all races in youth and staff; and

WHEREAS, furthermore, during Mr. Taylor's tenure, the Great Smoky Mountains YCC was the largest residential program of its kind in the nation and was selected to open the first co-ed residential program; from 1973 to 1976, Mr. Taylor chaired the National Training Cadre of

the YCC and worked with Southern Illinois University to create the national YCC education program entitled Acclimatization; and

WHEREAS, beginning in 1974, Tom Taylor was, alongside his family members, a partner in Drake Auto Parts, an automotive jobber started in 1946 that was the second of its kind in Tennessee to fully computerize in 1980; and

WHEREAS, by the time Mr. Taylor sold Drake Auto Parts in 2004, it was one of the five largest independent automotive jobbers in Tennessee; for one year after its sale, Mr. Taylor continued working as sales manager of the business; and

WHEREAS, in 1985, Tom Taylor and his wife, Janet "Nan" Krause Taylor, restored and converted the former home of the Maryville College president into a 155-seat fine dining restaurant called the Morningside Inn, which they operated until 1992; and

WHEREAS, from 1996 to 2018, Mr. Taylor served as president and CEO of Commercial Cutting Equipment, Inc., a commercial lawn equipment dealership in Maryville, and since his departure from that position, he has worked in equipment sales for the company and for MowerWorx; he also works as a substitute teacher for Maryville City Schools; and

WHEREAS, devoted to serving his fellow citizens, Mr. Taylor was first elected to the Maryville City Council in 2001 and served until 2020; during his tenure, he held the position of vice mayor from 2004 to 2008 and mayor from 2008 to 2020; and

WHEREAS, he is especially passionate about the public library system and served as chairman of the Blount County Board of Trustees during the building of the current Blount County Public Library; he was instrumental in creating the Foundation for the Blount County Public Library and also chaired the Fort Loudoun Regional Library Board and the State of Tennessee Advisory Council on Libraries (TACL); and

WHEREAS, while serving as chair of the TACL, he revised the minimum standards for Tennessee libraries, initiated specific standards of excellence for Tennessee libraries,

established the marketing program for State library services, and revised the long-range plan for Tennessee libraries; he also served as a member and the chair of the Tennessee Library Association; and

WHEREAS, Tom Taylor served four terms on the Board of the Great Smoky Mountains Association; during his three years as chair, the Association planned and opened three new retail outlets, remodeled the Sugarlands Visitors Center, created an independent Board of Directors for the Tremont Center, and provided the initial funding for Discover Life in America while still tripling funding to the Great Smoky Mountains National Park; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Taylor serves on several state and local boards, but he is particularly involved as one of the founders and the current board chair of SMiles, a ride-sharing program for seniors sponsored by the Blount County Community Action Agency; and

WHEREAS, Tom Taylor has been the board chair of the Maryville Housing Authority since 2023; in this role, he focuses his attention toward public housing and affordable housing; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Taylor has been active in Boy Scouts since his youth; he is an Eagle Scout and a Silver Beaver, and he also serves as a Cubmaster, Scoutmaster, and Explorer Advisor; he served on the Tuckaleechee District Scout Committee and the Local Troop Committee, and he is a member of the executive board of the Great Smoky Mountains Council, BSA; and

WHEREAS, Tom Taylor has participated in Shaped Note Old Harp singing for fifty years and is the moderator for three annual singings in the region; he is also a member of the Chancel Choir at Broadway United Methodist Church, where he has been a lifelong member and has also taught Sunday School for more than forty years; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Taylor and his wife raise and show American Kennel Club (AKC) registered bloodhounds; one of their dogs earned a championship and competed at the

Westminster Kennel Club show at Madison Square Garden, and another earned an AKC Grand Championship and was inducted into the American Bloodhound Club Hall of Fame; and

WHEREAS, Tom and Nan Taylor are the proud parents of two sons, Robert (Katie) and Benton (Sarah), and have been blessed with four grandchildren, Frank, Wade, Magnolia, and Olive; and

WHEREAS, as he celebrates his eightieth birthday, Mr. Taylor, admired for his wisdom, spirit of generosity, integrity, and enthusiasm for life, still exudes the goodness that is so characteristically his; and

WHEREAS, we wish to grasp this golden opportunity to specially recognize one of Tennessee's most outstanding citizens on this very special occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and congratulate Thomas William Taylor on the celebration of his eightieth birthday and extend to him our best wishes for many happy returns of the day.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.